

The 100 Year Story: How Theme Parks Built Central Florida's Economy

From a small zoo in Sanford and a set of botanical gardens to 79 million annual visitors — a full-model economic-impact analysis of Central Florida's theme park industry, 1924-2024.

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- Tool: Power BI · DAX
- Scope: 1924-2024
- Role: Data Analyst
- 29 parks tracked · 19 open · 10 closed
- Original model & theme design

79.0M

CF VISITORS, 2024

107K

THEME PARK JOBS, 2024

\$101

AVG ADULT TICKET

19 / 29

PARKS OPEN OF ALL TRACKED

01 · Overview

A 3,950x transformation in one century

In 1924, Central Florida hosted about 20,000 visitors — orange blossom rail tours and a small zoo in Sanford. No theme parks, no interstates, no airport. By 2024, the region drew 79.0 million visitors — a roughly 3,950x increase over one century, driven almost entirely by a single decision: building a theme park on 27,000 acres of swampland starting in 1971.

This model tracks all 29 theme parks ever opened in Central Florida (19 still open, 10 closed), across every operator from Walt Disney World and Universal Orlando down to independents like Gatorland and Fun Spot — plus the jobs, ticket pricing, airport capacity, and even the education programs the industry created around itself.

RECONCILING THE NUMBERS

Visitors: "79.0M CF Visitors 2024" (total regional tourism) and "76.9M Total Tracked Attendance" (summed theme-park gate visits, Themed Entertainment Association-style) are close in magnitude but measure different things — one visitor attending three parks in a trip counts once in the first figure and three times in the second.

Jobs: "107K Theme Park Jobs 2024" here means direct employment across theme park operators in this model. That's a much narrower number than the \$40.3B / 260,000-job figure Disney has separately reported to the public (an Oxford Economics study commissioned by Disney, covering indirect and induced statewide impact, not just direct theme-park headcount).

Oldest park: the KPI card reads 1923; the century framing below rounds to 1924–2024 for the "100 years" narrative — a one-year rounding difference, not a data error.

WHAT SURPRISED ME

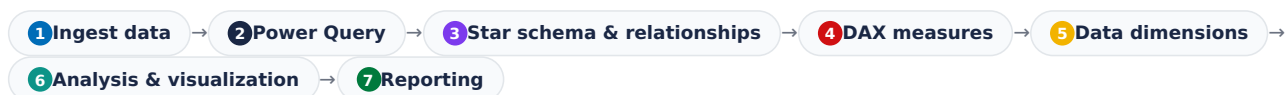
Since 1971, theme park jobs grew 8.9x while visitors grew only 5.6x. Employment consistently outpaced visitation — every additional visitor created more than one additional job. Tourism here isn't really a service industry; it behaves like a manufacturing line whose only product is experience.

Key takeaway: Visitor growth is the wrong headline metric for this industry's economic footprint — the jobs multiplier is the real story.

02 · Approach

The analyst workflow behind this report

This project follows a standard data-analyst pipeline end to end:



1. Ingest — a hand-built dataset of all 29 Central Florida theme parks (1924–2025), covering attendance, ticket pricing, employment, airport traffic, hotel rooms, and workforce education programs.

2. Power Query — *[transformation steps to follow]*.

3. Star schema & relationships — a shared **DimYear** dimension (Decade, DecadeSort, Era, EraSort, Year) connects four of the six tables — **EmploymentHistory**, **GrowthCorrelation**, **PopulationHistory**, and **VisitorHistory** — all active many-to-one on Year. **ThemeParkData** and **EducationPipeline** stand alone, each with its own year-type fields (OpeningDecade/ClosingYear, Founded/ClosedYear) rather than relating to DimYear. Full diagram in Section 03.

4. DAX measures — roughly 42 measures across six tables (ThemeParkData, PopulationHistory, GrowthCorrelation, EmploymentHistory, VisitorHistory, EducationPipeline) — full list in Section 03.

5. Data dimensions — a Decade/Year dimension spanning the 1920s–2020s drives every "growth since 1971" and "opened by decade" view in this report.

6. Analysis & visualization — five dashboard views covering parks, attendance, pricing, the jobs/infrastructure engine, and the education pipeline — covered in Section 04.

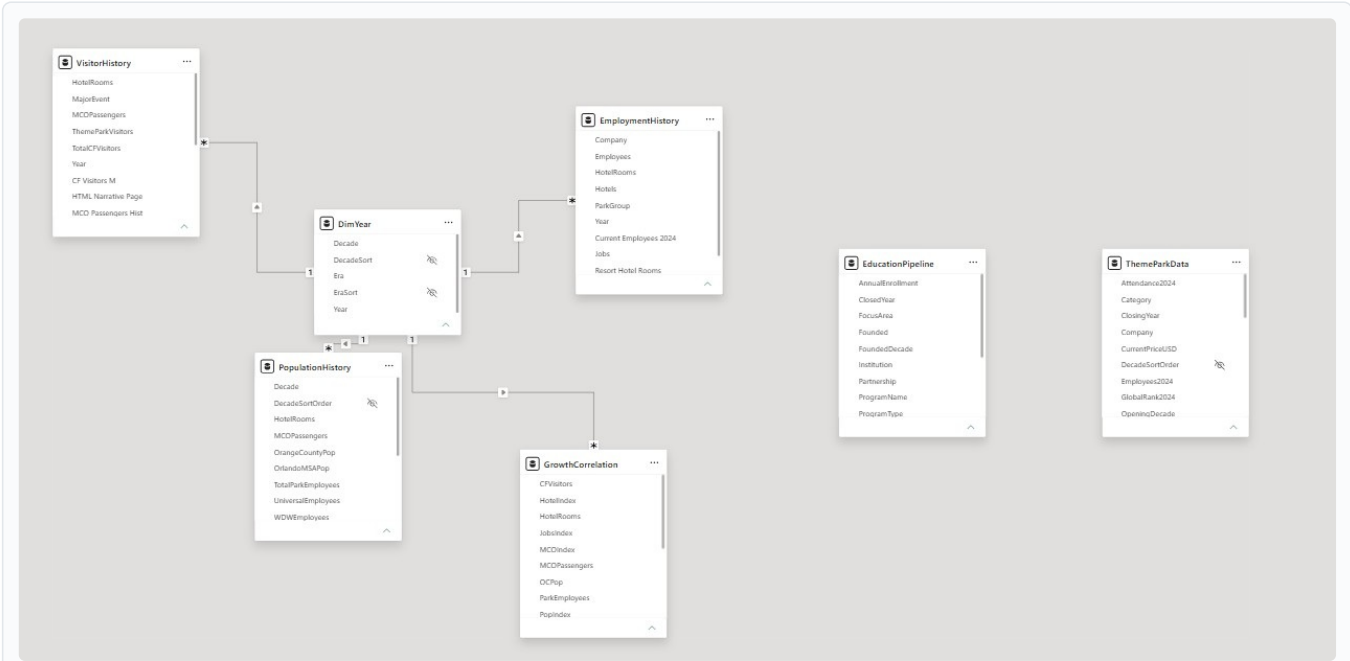
7. Reporting — this document, plus a one-page "100 Year Story" executive summary.

The semantic model and this report's design system were designed and built by me as part of this analysis — not a default template.

03 · Data Model

Semantic model & DAX relationships

The model is a partial star schema. A shared **DimYear** dimension (Decade, DecadeSort, Era, EraSort, Year) connects four tables via active many-to-one relationships on **Year**: **VisitorHistory** (HotelRooms, MajorEvent, MCOPassengers, ThemeParkVisitors, TotalCFVisitors), **EmploymentHistory** (Company, Employees, HotelRooms, Hotels, ParkGroup), **PopulationHistory** (HotelRooms, MCOPassengers, OrangeCountyPop, OrlandoMSAPop, TotalParkEmployees, UniversalEmployees, WDWEmployees), and **GrowthCorrelation** (CFVisitors, HotelIndex, HotelRooms, JobsIndex, MCOIndex, MCOPassengers, OCPop, ParkEmployees, PopIndex). **ThemeParkData** (Attendance2024, Category, ClosingYear, Company, CurrentPriceUSD, Employees2024, GlobalRank2024, OpeningDecade) and **EducationPipeline** (AnnualEnrollment, ClosedYear, FocusArea, Founded, FoundedDecade, Institution, Partnership, ProgramName, ProgramType) are standalone — each carries its own year-type fields rather than relating to DimYear.



Semantic model — DimYear sits at the center of four history tables (VisitorHistory, EmploymentHistory, PopulationHistory, GrowthCorrelation); ThemeParkData and EducationPipeline are unconnected, standalone tables.

Manage relationships

+ New relationship

Autodetect

EditDeleteFilter

☐ From: table (column) ↑	Relationship	To: table (column)	Status	
☐ EmploymentHistory (Year)	* — 1	DimYear (Year)	Active	...
☐ GrowthCorrelation (Year)	* — 1	DimYear (Year)	Active	...
☐ PopulationHistory (Year)	* — 1	DimYear (Year)	Active	...
☐ VisitorHistory (Year)	* — 1	DimYear (Year)	Active	...

Manage Relationships view — exactly four active relationships, all on **Year**, confirming ThemeParkData and EducationPipeline have none.

RELATIONSHIPS, AS WRITTEN TO RELATIONSHIPS.TMDL

#	From (Many side)	To (One side)	Column
R01	VisitorHistory	DimYear	Year
R02	PopulationHistory	DimYear	Year
R03	EmploymentHistory	DimYear	Year

DimYear acts as the single time axis for this model — slicing by Decade or Era cross-filters all four connected tables simultaneously. **ThemeParkData** and **EducationPipeline** remain standalone: their OpeningYear / Founded fields are descriptive columns only, not relationship keys, so slicing DimYear has no effect on either of those two tables.

PENDING

Power Query transformation steps will be added here once provided, following the same step-by-step format as the LEGO case study.

KEY DAX MEASURES — THEMEPARKDATA (18 MEASURES SHOWN; SOURCE LABEL SAID 13)

The count in the source notes didn't match the number of formulas provided — 18 are listed here, all with formulas, so all 18 are shown rather than guessing which 5 to omit.

Park Count
Park Count = COUNTROWS (ThemeParkData)
The base row count for every "parks tracked" figure in the model.
Parks Open
Parks Open = CALCULATE (COUNTROWS (ThemeParkData), ThemeParkData[Status] = "Open")
Filters the base count to one status — the 19 in "19/29 open" KPI.
Parks Closed
Parks Closed = CALCULATE (COUNTROWS (ThemeParkData), ThemeParkData[Status] = "Closed")
Same pattern as Parks Open, filtered to "Closed" — the 10 closed parks.
Parks With Attendance
Parks With Attendance = COUNTROWS (FILTER (ThemeParkData, ThemeParkData[Attendance2024] > 0))
Uses a row-level FILTER rather than CALCULATE since it's testing a numeric threshold, not a category match — counts only parks with real 2024 data, not blanks or zeros.
Ranked Parks
Ranked Parks = COUNTROWS (FILTER (ThemeParkData, ThemeParkData[GlobalRank2024] > 0))
Same FILTER pattern, applied to global-rank data — the "6 parks in world top 15" KPI.
Total Attendance M
Total Attendance M = IF (SUM (ThemeParkData[Attendance2024]) = 0, BLANK(), ROUND (DIVIDE (SUM (ThemeParkData[Attendance2024]), 1000000), 1))
The IF/BLANK() wrapper prevents the KPI from showing a misleading "0.0" when a filter context has no attendance data at all — the 76.9M Total Tracked Attendance KPI.
Attendance M
Attendance M = IF (MAX (ThemeParkData[Attendance2024]) = 0, BLANK(), ROUND (DIVIDE (MAX (ThemeParkData[Attendance2024]), 1000000), 1))
Uses MAX instead of SUM — designed for single-park context (e.g. one bar in the "2024 Attendance by Park" chart), not an aggregate total.
Disney Attendance M
Disney Attendance M =

```

CALCULATE (
    ROUND (DIVIDE (SUM (ThemeParkData [Attendance2024]), 1000000), 1),
    ThemeParkData [Company] = "Walt Disney World"
)

```

Hardcodes the company filter inside CALCULATE rather than relying on a slicer — guarantees this KPI always reads Disney's total regardless of what else is selected on the page. Drives the 51.8M Disney Attendance KPI.

Universal Attendance M

```

Universal Attendance M =
    CALCULATE (
        ROUND (DIVIDE (SUM (ThemeParkData [Attendance2024]), 1000000), 1),
        ThemeParkData [Company] = "Universal Orlando"
    )

```

Same fixed-filter pattern as Disney Attendance M — the 20.8M Universal figure, and together the basis for the "over 94% of attendance" concentration finding.

Avg Ticket Price

```

Avg Ticket Price =
    AVERAGEX (
        FILTER (ThemeParkData, ThemeParkData [Status] = "Open" && ThemeParkData [CurrentPriceUSD] > 0),
        ThemeParkData [CurrentPriceUSD]
    )

```

AVERAGEX over a filtered table (open parks only, with a real price) rather than a plain AVERAGE column reference — closed parks and missing prices can't quietly drag the \$101 average down.

Current Price

```

Current Price =
    IF (MAX (ThemeParkData [CurrentPriceUSD]) = 0, BLANK (), MAX (ThemeParkData [CurrentPriceUSD]))

```

Single-park price lookup — the \$169 Epic Universe "Highest Current Price" KPI.

Opening Price

```

Opening Price =
    IF (MAX (ThemeParkData [OpeningPriceUSD]) = 0, BLANK (), MAX (ThemeParkData [OpeningPriceUSD]))

```

The historical counterpart to Current Price — feeds Price Multiple below.

Price Multiple

```

Price Multiple =
    IF (MAX (ThemeParkData [OpeningPriceUSD]) = 0, BLANK (),
        ROUND (DIVIDE (MAX (ThemeParkData [CurrentPriceUSD]), MAX (ThemeParkData [OpeningPriceUSD])), 1))

```

Current ÷ Opening price, guarded against a missing opening price — the measure behind Magic Kingdom's roughly 40x figure.

Global Rank Score

```

Global Rank Score =
    IF (MAX (ThemeParkData [GlobalRank2024]) = 0, BLANK (), 26 - MAX (ThemeParkData [GlobalRank2024]))

```

Inverts rank into a score (26 minus rank) so higher bars mean better position — rank 1 becomes a score of 25, the tallest bar in the chart, rather than the shortest.

Years Operating

```

Years Operating =
    IF (MAX (ThemeParkData [ClosingYear]) > 0,
        MAX (ThemeParkData [ClosingYear]) - MAX (ThemeParkData [OpeningYear]),
        2024 - MAX (ThemeParkData [OpeningYear]))

```

Branches on whether a park has closed — closed parks get their actual lifespan, open parks get years-since-opening through 2024. This single measure powers both the "closed parks show actual run" and "open parks show years since founding" logic noted in the dashboard captions.

Oldest Park Year

Oldest Park Year = MIN(ThemeParkData[OpeningYear])

The 1923 KPI — one year off the "1924" rounded in the century narrative, as flagged in the Overview.

Newest Park Year

Newest Park Year = MAX(ThemeParkData[OpeningYear])

2025 — Epic Universe, the newest park in the dataset.

Company Jobs 2024

Company Jobs 2024 =
IF(MAX(ThemeParkData[Employees2024]) = 0, BLANK(), MAX(ThemeParkData[Employees2024]))

Per-company employment lookup — feeds the "Theme Park Employment by Company" bar chart (Disney ~75K, Universal ~25K, and the smaller independents).

KEY DAX MEASURES — POPULATIONHISTORY (5 OF 5)

CF Population

CF Population = MAX(PopulationHistory[OrangeCountyPop])

The 2M Orange County Population KPI.

Hotel Rooms

Hotel Rooms = MAX(PopulationHistory[HotelRooms])

Feeds the "hotel rooms grew 8.25x" infrastructure-correlation finding.

MCO Passengers

MCO Passengers = MAX(PopulationHistory[MCOPassengers])

The airport-traffic side of the infrastructure correlation — 52.0M by 2024.

WDW Hotel Rooms Pop

WDW Hotel Rooms Pop = MAX(PopulationHistory[WDWHotelRooms])

A Disney-specific hotel-room count, separate from the region-wide Hotel Rooms measure above.

Total Park Jobs Historical

Total Park Jobs Historical = MAX(PopulationHistory[TotalParkEmployees])

The long-run jobs series this table tracks alongside population and infrastructure, for the "jobs grew 8.9x" growth-correlation view.

KEY DAX MEASURES — GROWTHCORRELATION (6 OF 6)

Visitors Index

Visitors Index =
IF(MAX(GrowthCorrelation[VisitorsIndex]) = 0, BLANK(), MAX(GrowthCorrelation[VisitorsIndex]))

One of three indices (visitors, jobs, population) all rebased to 1971 = 100 — this is the 5.6x line in the growth-correlation chart.

Jobs Index

Jobs Index =
IF(MAX(GrowthCorrelation[JobsIndex]) = 0, BLANK(), MAX(GrowthCorrelation[JobsIndex]))

Same rebasing pattern — the 8.9x line, and the whole basis of the "what surprised me" finding in the Overview.

Pop Index

Pop Index =
IF (MAX (GrowthCorrelation[PopIndex]) = 0, BLANK(), MAX (GrowthCorrelation[PopIndex]))

The 4.4x population line, completing the three-way growth comparison.

MCO Index

MCO Index =
IF (MAX (GrowthCorrelation[MCOIndex]) = 0, BLANK(), MAX (GrowthCorrelation[MCOIndex]))

The 20.8x airport-passenger line in the infrastructure-correlation chart.

Hotel Index

Hotel Index =
IF (MAX (GrowthCorrelation[HotelIndex]) = 0, BLANK(), MAX (GrowthCorrelation[HotelIndex]))

The 8.25x hotel-room line, paired with MCO Index in the same chart.

Visitor Job Ratio

Visitor Job Ratio =
IF (MAX (GrowthCorrelation[ParkEmployees]) = 0, BLANK(),
ROUND (DIVIDE (MAX (GrowthCorrelation[CFVisitors]), MAX (GrowthCorrelation[ParkEmployees])), 0))

Visitors per employee, the inverse framing of the jobs-multiplier story — a falling ratio over time is exactly what "jobs grew faster than visitors" looks like from this angle.

KEY DAX MEASURES — EMPLOYMENTHISTORY (4 OF 4)

Jobs

Jobs = SUM (EmploymentHistory[Employees])

The base measure behind the WDW employment-history line: 12,000 (1971) → 77,000 (2019) → 38,000 (COVID) → 75,000 (2024).

Current Employees 2024

Current Employees 2024 =
CALCULATE (SUM (EmploymentHistory[Employees]), EmploymentHistory[Year] = 2024)

A year-locked variant of Jobs — the 107K "Theme Park Jobs 2024" headline KPI, independent of whatever year a slicer might otherwise select.

Resort Hotels

Resort Hotels = MAX (EmploymentHistory[Hotels])

The 28 Resort Hotels KPI.

Resort Hotel Rooms

Resort Hotel Rooms = MAX (EmploymentHistory[HotelRooms])

A second hotel-room figure tracked in this table, alongside the region-wide and Disney-specific versions elsewhere in the model.

KEY DAX MEASURES — VISITORHISTORY (9 MEASURES; 6 SHOWN WITH FORMULAS, 3 ABBREVIATED)

Total CF Visitors

Total CF Visitors = MAX (VisitorHistory[TotalCFVisitors])

The raw figure behind the 79.0M "CF Visitors 2024" KPI, before rounding to millions.

Theme Park Visitors Hist

Theme Park Visitors Hist = MAX(VisitorHistory[ThemeParkVisitors])

The historical time series behind the "1970 vs 1971" 274% Disney Effect surge.

MCO Passengers Hist

MCO Passengers Hist = MAX(VisitorHistory[MCOPassengers])

A second MCO passenger series tracked here, alongside PopulationHistory's version.

CF Visitors M

CF Visitors M =
IF(MAX(VisitorHistory[TotalCFVisitors]) = 0, BLANK(),
ROUND(DIVIDE(MAX(VisitorHistory[TotalCFVisitors]), 1000000), 1))

The millions-rounded display version of Total CF Visitors — same IF/BLANK/ROUND/DIVIDE pattern used throughout the model for consistency.

Theme Park Visitors M

Theme Park Visitors M =
IF(MAX(VisitorHistory[ThemeParkVisitors]) = 0, BLANK(),
ROUND(DIVIDE(MAX(VisitorHistory[ThemeParkVisitors]), 1000000), 1))

Millions-rounded version of the theme-park-specific visitor series.

MCO Passengers M

MCO Passengers M =
IF(MAX(VisitorHistory[MCOPassengers]) = 0, BLANK(),
ROUND(DIVIDE(MAX(VisitorHistory[MCOPassengers]), 1000000), 1))

Millions-rounded MCO passenger figure — the 52.0M KPI.

'Story' measures (×6)

FORMULAS NOT PROVIDED

1. Story Century — 1924 vs. 2024 visitors, calculates the ×growth figure
2. Story Disney Effect — 1970 vs. 1971 visitor surge %
3. Story Jobs Engine — visitor growth vs. job growth multipliers
4. Story MCO Airport — MCO passenger 20× growth
5. Story The Parks — park count open/closed, the Cypress Gardens story
6. Story Education — active programs and enrollment count

These are almost certainly dynamic DAX string measures (likely built with **VAR/SELECTEDVALUE/&** concatenation) that generate the actual sentences on the "100 Year Story" summary card — but the formulas themselves weren't included in what was shared. Worth adding once available, since they're the most narratively interesting measures in the model.

KEY DAX MEASURES — EDUCATIONPIPELINE (5 OF 5)

Programs Open
Programs Open = CALCULATE (COUNTROWS (EducationPipeline), EducationPipeline[Status] = "Open")
The 10 "Programs Active" KPI.
Programs Closed
Programs Closed = CALCULATE (COUNTROWS (EducationPipeline), EducationPipeline[Status] = "Closed")
The 1 closed program.
Program Count
Program Count = COUNTROWS (EducationPipeline)
The base row count — 11 programs tracked in total (10 open + 1 closed).
Total Annual Enrollment
Total Annual Enrollment = CALCULATE (SUM (EducationPipeline[AnnualEnrollment]), EducationPipeline[Status] = "Open")
Filtered to open programs only — a closed program's historical enrollment shouldn't inflate the "current" 33K total. This is the 33,380 KPI.
Enrollment
Enrollment = IF (SUM (EducationPipeline[AnnualEnrollment]) = 0, BLANK (), SUM (EducationPipeline[AnnualEnrollment]))
An unfiltered variant of Total Annual Enrollment, used per-institution in the "Annual Enrollment by Institution" and "Annual Enrollment by Program" bar charts (Full Sail's 12K, Disney College Program's 5K, etc.), where the Status filter isn't needed since each row is already one specific program.

04 · Insights

The 100 Year Story, six ways

The 100 Year Story

How a small zoo in Sanford, a set of botanical gardens, and one October morning in 1971 transformed a subtropical orange grove into the most visited tourist destination on Earth.

100

1924 — 2024

● **Live in Power BI** — Every value on this page is a DAX measure in the Themeparks.pbip report. Refresh the dataset and the narrative recalculates automatically.

01

The Century: 1924 — 2024

In 1924, Central Florida hosted **20K** visitors — orange blossom rail tours and a small zoo in Sanford. No theme parks. No interstates. No airport. In 2024: **79.0M** visitors annually. A **3,950x** transformation in one century, driven entirely by the decision to build a theme park on 27,000 acres of swampland.

02

The Disney Effect: One Park Changed Everything

Walt Disney World opened October 1, 1971. The year before: **3.8M** visitors. Opening year: **14.2M**. A **274%** surge in a single year — the sharpest inflection in Florida tourism history. Every major expansion that followed — EPCOT, Universal, Islands of Adventure, Epic Universe — traces its rationale back to that single opening week.

03

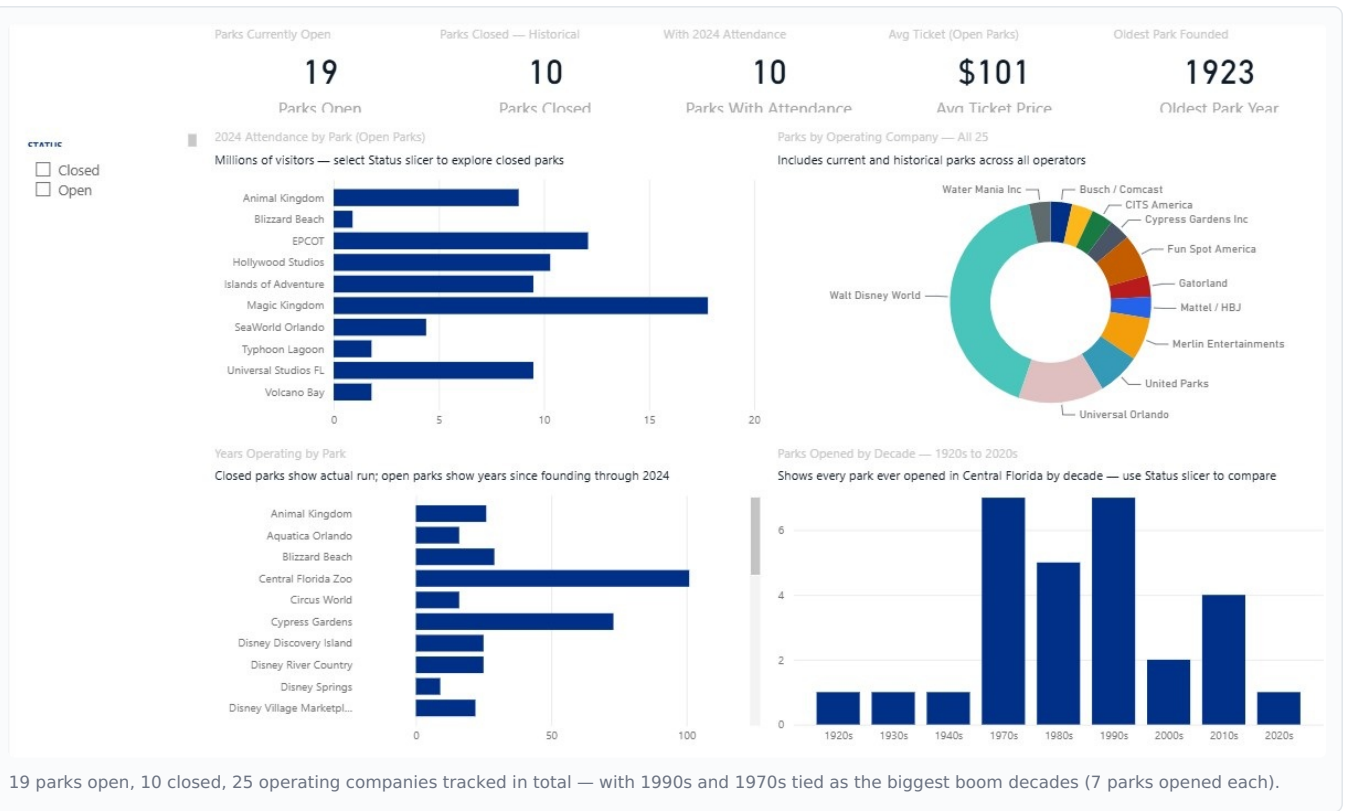
The Jobs Engine: Employment Outpaces Visitation

Visitors grew **5.6x** since 1971. Theme park jobs grew **8.9x**. Employment consistently outpaced visitation — every additional visitor created more than one additional job. By 2024: **107K** theme park workers in Central Florida. Tourism is not a service industry; it is a manufacturing line with no product except experience.

Live HTML narrative widget from the Power BI report, rendered directly rather than a screenshot — the six findings this dashboard is built around, 1924–2024.

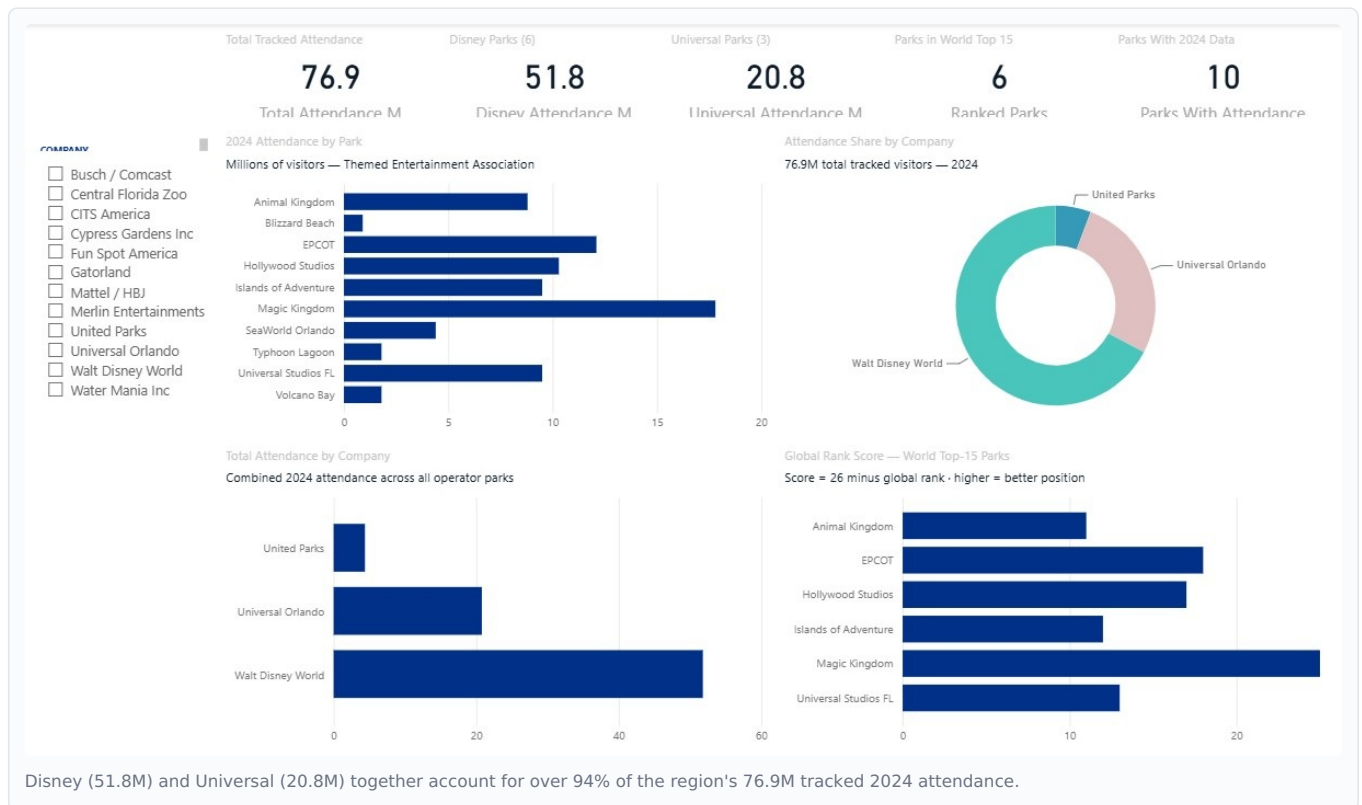
THE DISNEY EFFECT: ONE PARK CHANGED EVERYTHING

The year before Walt Disney World opened (1970), Central Florida drew an estimated 3.8M visitors. Its opening year (1971) drew 14.2M — a 274% surge in a single year, the sharpest inflection point in Florida tourism history. Every major expansion that followed — EPCOT, Universal, Islands of Adventure, Epic Universe — traces its rationale back to that one opening week.



MARKET STRUCTURE: TWO COMPANIES, MOST OF THE MARKET

Of 76.9M total tracked 2024 attendance, Walt Disney World's six parks alone account for 51.8M (roughly two-thirds), and Universal's three parks add another 20.8M — together over 94% of all tracked Central Florida theme park attendance. Six Central Florida parks rank in the world's top 15 by global attendance, with Magic Kingdom at the top of that list.



PRICING: A 40X GAP BETWEEN THE OLDEST TICKET AND TODAY'S

Average adult admission across tracked parks is \$101, topping out at \$169 for the newest park (Epic Universe, opening 2025). Magic Kingdom shows the widest opening-to-current price multiple of any park in the dataset — roughly 40x its original gate price — reflecting over 50 years of pricing power built on that first 1971 surge.



THE JOBS ENGINE AND THE AIRPORT THAT HAD TO KEEP UP

Indexed to 1971 = 100, theme park jobs grew 8.9x, visitors 5.6x, and regional population 4.4x — confirming the employment-multiplier effect noted in the Overview. Infrastructure tracked the same curve: Orlando International Airport (originally McCoy Air Force Base, handling 2.5M passengers in 1971) grew 20.8x to 52.0M passengers by 2024, and resort hotel rooms grew 8.25x over the same period — both driven by theme park visitor demand rather than the reverse. Walt Disney World's own employment history traces the industry's volatility directly: 12,000 employees in 1971 → 77,000 by 2019 → a sharp COVID-era drop to 38,000 → recovery to 75,000 by 2024.



Terminal C at MCO opened in 2022, timed directly to Epic Universe's 2025 opening — a pattern that holds throughout the dataset: every major park expansion triggers a corresponding airport expansion, typically arriving just ahead of it.

THE PIPELINE: AN EDUCATION SYSTEM THE PARKS CREATED THEMSELVES

Ten active workforce programs — anchored by Full Sail University (12K annual enrollment), the Disney College Program

(5K), Orange County Public Schools' CTE hospitality track (5K), and UCF's Rosen College (3.5K) — now enroll 33,380 students a year across hospitality, entertainment, attractions, and workforce-development tracks. The oldest of these programs launched in 1975, four years after Walt Disney World opened. None of them existed before that October morning in 1971.



SURVIVAL REQUIRES REINVENTION — OR PROXIMITY TO A MOUSE

Cypress Gardens, the original Florida attraction (opened 1936, 35 years before Disney), ran for 73 years before closing — the longest run of any independent park in the dataset. By contrast, River Country closed without any public announcement, and Pleasure Island's nightclub district shut down in a single night in 2008. Of the 10 closed parks, nearly all were independent operators rather than Disney or Universal properties — the market has consolidated hard around the two largest anchors.

05 · Recommendations

The transferable takeaway

- **Report the jobs multiplier, not just visitor counts** — jobs grew 8.9x against 5.6x visitor growth since 1971; employment, not attendance, is the more revealing economic-impact headline for this industry.
- **Track market concentration explicitly** — two operators (Disney, Universal) account for over 94% of tracked 2024 attendance; monitor that concentration ratio the same way a portfolio analyst would track customer concentration risk.
- **Treat infrastructure growth as a leading indicator** — airport and hotel capacity tracked theme park demand almost exactly (20.8x and 8.25x since 1971), and Terminal C's 2022 opening ahead of Epic Universe (2025) shows infrastructure investment timed in anticipation of, not reaction to, park expansion.
- **Independent operators need a reinvention strategy, not just proximity** — nearly all closures in the dataset are independent parks; Cypress Gardens' 73-year run shows sustained differentiation is possible, but the market has otherwise consolidated hard around the two largest anchors.
- **Workforce pipeline growth is a durable maturity signal** — 33,380 annual program enrollments, none of which existed before 1971, indicate an industry that has built lasting institutional infrastructure beyond ticket sales and attendance.